stop showing up. Abhishek Singh, Learnet's COO, says their trainers often accompany candidates to interviews—even across states—and support them during the first week at work to prevent dropouts. Employability, argues the ex-MSDE official, depends on factors beyond training, including broader economic conditions and candidates' willingness to relocate. Many feel uncomfortable moving for work, he says, leading to high dropout rates within the first two months of employment, weakening outcomes.

The yardstick for measuring outcomes also continues to be less than optimally stable. In the first three phases, a candidate was considered placed after working continuously for three months. In PMKVY 4.0, oddly, placement outcomes were delinked from the skilling process. But in March 2025, the Parliamentary Standing Committee on Labour, Textiles and Skill Development harked back to the old ideal. It asked MSDE to furnish placement data for PMKVY 4.0, describing it as the "real barometer" of its success, while also underscoring the need for an independent evaluation of training quality.

WEAK MONITORING

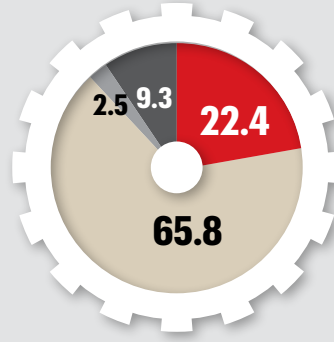
Poor internal controls allowed widespread deviations from norms on that front. The CAG found MSDE had no policy for retaining electronic records of training activities, making it difficult to verify quality. Information such as participant attendance, trainer details and the geographic location of training centres under PMKVY 1.0 was not retained. Under the RPL component, TPs were required to take photos and make videos of the certificate distribution ceremonies and upload batch-wise group photographs of candidates to an NSDC portal. Yet NSDC itself did not retain this data, leaving little documentary evidence that training had even taken place. A formal Data Governance Framework was notified only in April 2022, after the first three phases had concluded.

Eligibility norms were also weakly enforced. Across all phases, minimum age, educational qualifications and sometimes prior experience were prescribed for different job roles. But the enrolment process lacked a reliable verification mechanism. As a result, 654,000 certified candidates were found to be below the minimum entry

WHY INDIA MUST FIX ITS SKILLS PROBLEM

India's skilling crisis is stark. A majority of workers possess only informal skills. Nearly 90% remain in low-competency roles

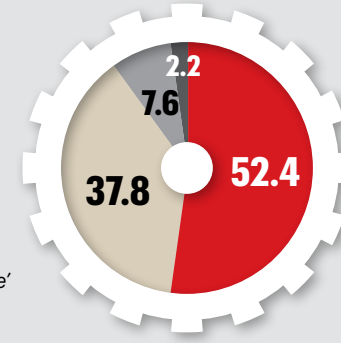
Occupational profile of India's workforce according to skill levels (%)



- Very low-competency
- Low-competency
- Mid-competency
- High-competency

Education level of India's workforce (%)

- Primary/up to 10 yrs of education or informal skills
- Secondary/ up to 11-13 yrs of education
- Graduation/ up to 14-15 yrs of education
- Postgraduation/ more than 15 yrs of education



Source: 'Skills for the Future: Transforming India's Workforce Landscape' by the Institute for Competitiveness (PLFS data from 2017-18 to 2023-24)

REBOOTING PMKVY

How to make the skilling programme work more effectively

- Mandate placement linkages and prior skilling experience for training partners (TPs)
- Expand industry ties beyond the top firms; partner with MSMEs and incentivise those in global supply chains to build skilling verticals
- Undertake granular sectoral mapping—by city and district—to align training with local demand
- Restrict TPs to sectors relevant to their expertise
- Adapt PMKVY to the Recruit–Train–Deploy model adopted by states like Jharkhand and Bihar
- Enforce structured progression pathways for candidates; prevent enrolment at advanced levels without assessment
- Offer long-term budget allocations and targets to TPs, instead of annual, to enable better planning
- Shift focus from infrastructure to improving student and trainer quality, and to designing programmes suited to weaker sections
- Integrate skilling into the formal education system rather than treating it as a post-school/ college add-on